

THE GIST TABLE

The Jollof Wars – Who Really Owns the Pot?

Hosted by Tomi & Ada

[COLD OPEN]

TOMI: Let me just say this before we even start the music. If you invite me to a wedding, and by the time I get to the reception, they tell me "Ah, bro, the Jollof has finished, but we have fried rice"—I am taking my wedding gift back. I'm carrying my blender and I am going home.

ADA: [Laughs] Tomi, you cannot repossess a blender just because of rice!

TOMI: Ada, it is a breach of contract! The invitation card says "Reception to follow." The unspoken addendum is "Party Jollof will be present." If it is not present, the marriage is void. I don't make the rules!

ADA: [Laughing] Oh my goodness. Let's just start the show before you get us cancelled by the Association of Nigerian Caterers.

[INTRO MUSIC FADES IN - UPBEAT AFROBEATS WITH A HEAVY BASSLINE AND TALKING DRUM]

TOMI: Welcome back, family! You are listening to *The Gist Table*, the only podcast where the conversations are as spicy as the food we eat. I'm your boy, Tomi!

ADA: And I'm Ada. Welcome back to the table, everyone. Pull up a chair.

TOMI: Today, we are touching a very sensitive subject. A subject that has broken friendships, caused Twitter meltdowns, and divided the great continent of Africa.

ADA: It is the culinary Cold War that has been raging for decades. Today, we are settling—or rather, exploring—the legendary, the iconic, the never-ending Jollof Wars!

TOMI: Who owns the pot?! Who makes it best?! Spoiler alert: It's Nigeria.

ADA: [Sighs] And here we go. Folks, stick around, because today we are diving deep into the history, the culture, the myths, and the absolute hilarity of Jollof rice.

[MUSIC SWELLS AND THEN FADES OUT]

[TRANSITION STING]

SEGMENT 1 – ORIGINS

TOMI: Okay, Professor Ada. Before I start bragging about firewood and bottom-pot, let's go to the classroom. Where did this beautiful, red, majestic dish actually come from? Because my uncle Tunde swears it was invented in Surulere in the 1970s.

ADA: Uncle Tunde is very, very wrong. To find the true origins of Jollof, we have to go back way before the 1970s. We're talking about the 14th to the 19th century, specifically the Jolof—or Wolof—Empire. This empire spanned across what is now modern-day Senegal, The Gambia, and Mauritania.

TOMI: Respect to the ancestors!

ADA: Exactly! The dish we now call Jollof originated there. It's traditionally called *Thiéboudienne* in Senegal, or *Benachin* in The Gambia, which literally translates to "one pot."

TOMI: One pot. One love.

ADA: Exactly. The Senegalese version, *Thiéboudienne*, was historically made with broken rice, fresh and dried fish, tomatoes, and a rich array of vegetables like cassava, eggplant, and carrots. It was born out of resourcefulness, using local ingredients along the coast.

TOMI: So how did it go from Senegal to causing Twitter wars between Accra and Lagos?

ADA: Well, the Wolof people were phenomenal traders. During the colonial era and pre-colonial trade routes, they moved across West Africa. Additionally, the French colonial administration brought agricultural workers from Senegal to other parts of West Africa, like Mali and Guinea. As the people moved, the recipe moved. And as the recipe moved, it adapted to whatever local ingredients were available.

TOMI: That makes sense. Because if you drop a Senegalese recipe in Nigeria, we are going to look at it and say, "Needs more pepper!"

ADA: Exactly! By the time it reached the Gold Coast—now Ghana—and Nigeria, the fish was often swapped for goat, beef, or chicken, and the spice profiles shifted entirely. The broken

rice of Senegal was replaced by long-grain or parboiled rice. But the soul of the dish—cooking the rice in a rich tomato and pepper stew—remained exactly the same.

[TRANSITION STING]

SEGMENT 2 – THE REGIONAL TOUR

TOMI: Okay, since the recipe traveled, let's take our listeners on a tour. A Jollof Safari, if you will.

ADA: Let's do it. We have to start with the originators: Senegal.

TOMI: Big up, Dakar!

ADA: Senegalese *Thiéboudienne* is incredibly rich. They use broken rice, which absorbs flavor beautifully. It's stuffed full of seafood flavor. They often stuff the fish with a parsley and garlic mix called *rof*, and the rice is cooked in the broth of the fish and vegetables. It's herbaceous, deeply savory, and usually served with a side of tamarind sauce for a sour kick.

TOMI: Now, let's jump on a flight to Nigeria. The heavyweight champions. We use parboiled rice—specifically, long-grain parboiled. The secret to our Jollof is the holy trinity of tomatoes, onions, and *tatashe*—red bell peppers—blended with scotch bonnets. We don't play with our heat.

ADA: You really don't.

TOMI: And the method is key! We steam it. And if it's a party, it goes into a massive cast-iron pot over an open firewood flame. The smoke infuses into the rice, and the bottom burns just a little bit to give you that crunchy, smoky "bottom pot." Served with fried plantain—*dodo*—and a piece of chicken that has been fried and then soaked in pepper sauce. Masterpiece.

ADA: Very poetic, Tomi. But let's cross the border to Ghana.

TOMI: [Clears throat loudly] Oh, are they involved?

ADA: Stop it! Ghanaian Jollof is elite. They typically use perfumed rice, like Jasmine or Basmati. Because of this, the rice grains stay very distinct and fluffy. Their base is heavily reliant on a very rich, dark tomato stew, often spiced with ginger, garlic, and sometimes star anise or nutmeg. It's incredibly aromatic. Because Jasmine rice doesn't take as much water, it has a completely different texture to Nigerian Jollof. They usually pair it with *shito*, a phenomenal black pepper sauce.

TOMI: Okay, I will admit, *shito* is magic. But what about Sierra Leone and Liberia?

ADA: Sierra Leonean and Liberian Jollof are the hidden gems of West Africa. They often mix meats—you'll find beef, chicken, and sometimes seafood all in the same pot. Sierra Leoneans might add local greens or unique spice blends, while Liberians are famous for their hearty, rich versions that don't hold back on the oil or the proteins. It's a feast in a single pot.

TOMI: And let's not forget Gambia! *Benachin!* Similar to Senegal, but they have their own swagger with it. Honestly, it's just beautiful how one concept has a thousand correct answers.

[TRANSITION STING]

SEGMENT 3 – MYTHBUSTERS

ADA: Alright, let's play a game. It's time for Jollof Mythbusters. I'll read a myth, we debate it, and we declare it fact or fiction.

TOMI: Let's go.

ADA: Myth number 1: "Jollof is just tomato rice."

TOMI: Fiction! Abomination! Blasphemy! If you boil rice and pour tomato ketchup on it, you are making a tragedy, not Jollof.

ADA: Correct. Jollof requires the rice to be cooked *in* the spiced broth. It absorbs the flavor. It's not a sauce added later. Myth 2: "There is only one authentic recipe."

TOMI: Fiction! Even in my own house, my mother makes it differently than my grandmother. The beauty of Jollof is adaptation.

ADA: Exactly. Myth 3: "Only Nigerians make Party Jollof."

TOMI: ...Wait, is this a trick question?

ADA: Tomi, be honest.

TOMI: Okay, fine, fiction. Ghanaians have massive parties, Senegalese have massive parties. Everyone cooks in bulk. But... Nigerian party Jollof has the best PR!

ADA: I'll accept that. Myth 4: "You must use imported rice to make good Jollof."

TOMI: Big fiction! In fact, locally grown rice, like Ofada in Nigeria, gives it a crazy, earthy flavor. The whole "imported is better" thing is just colonial hangover.

ADA: Spot on. Myth 5: "Jollof should always be spicy enough to make you sweat."

TOMI: Fact! If I don't need a towel while eating, the Jollof is weak!

ADA: [Laughs] Fiction! Not everyone tolerates high heat. Senegalese and Ghanaian Jollof focus more on aromatics and umami than pure chili heat.

TOMI: Okay, fine. But I still want to sweat.

ADA: Myth 6: "Ghanaians use too much ginger in their Jollof."

TOMI: [Laughs] Let me not speak, lest I am attacked on Twitter.

ADA: Fiction! It's just a different flavor profile. The ginger complements the Jasmine rice perfectly. Myth 7: "Bottom pot is unhealthy."

TOMI: Fiction! Bottom pot cures depression. It heals the soul.

ADA: Medically speaking, eating heavily charred food isn't the best for you, but culturally, it is the prize of the pot. And finally, Myth 8: "Jollof is difficult to cook."

TOMI: Fact. Getting the rice to par-cook in the sauce without turning to mush or burning entirely takes a PhD in vibes and ancestral guidance.

ADA: It's definitely a dish of intuition. You have to measure the water with your heart.

[TRANSITION STING]

SEGMENT 4 – FRIENDLY DEBATES

ADA: Moving on to the debates. Let's rapid-fire some of the most controversial Jollof topics. Firewood vs. Gas stove?

TOMI: Firewood. It's not even close. The smoke is an ingredient.

ADA: I agree for parties. But for a Tuesday night after work? Gas stove, please. I am not chopping wood in my pajamas. Next: Bottom pot vs. Top layer?

TOMI: Bottom pot. The crunch! The concentration of spices!

ADA: I'm a top layer girl. I like my rice fluffy and distinct. Bottom pot hurts my teeth.

TOMI: You are soft, Ada. Soft!

ADA: Whatever. Chicken or Turkey?

TOMI: Ah. Hard-fried Turkey that has been swimming in pepper sauce. The meat is tougher, it holds the flavor better.

ADA: Soft, succulent chicken thigh for me. Next: Plantain vs. Salad?

TOMI: Plantain! *Dodo!* The sweetness cuts the spice. Salad just makes the plate wet. Why is there mayonnaise near my Jollof?!

ADA: Because the creamy coleslaw balances the heat! It's a textural masterpiece! You guys are sleeping on a good Jollof and coleslaw combo.

TOMI: Keep your cabbage away from my heritage.

ADA: Next: Homemade Jollof vs. Wedding Jollof?

TOMI: Wedding Jollof. Specifically, the one served around 6:00 PM when the aunties have stopped fighting and the music is loud.

ADA: I actually prefer Homemade. My mom's Jollof, made on a Sunday, with massive chunks of beef inside it. Unbeatable.

TOMI: Finally... Wooden spoon vs. Modern cookware for stirring?

TOMI & ADA: Wooden spoon!

ADA: You need that heavy wooden paddle to scrape the bottom properly! A silicone spatula will just snap in half.

[TRANSITION STING]

SEGMENT 5 – AUDIENCE REACTIONS

TOMI: We took this debate to social media, and you guys did not disappoint. We asked for your funniest Jollof stories and opinions. Let's read a few.

ADA: First one is a tweet from @Kwame_The_Great in Accra. He says: "Nigerians use firewood to cook Jollof because their rice is so tough, it needs a natural disaster to soften it. Ghana Jollof forever. 🇬🇭"

TOMI: [Laughs] Kwame, Kwame, Kwame. Your Jasmine rice smells like a perfume factory! We are cooking food, not Dior!

ADA: Behave! Okay, here's an Instagram comment from @NgoziBakes: "In my university hostel, a girl tried to make Jollof in an electric kettle because gas finished. She ended up making spicy red oatmeal. We still call her Chef Porridge to this day."

TOMI: See, the struggle is real! I used to make concoction rice with an iron in my dorm. Desperate times!

ADA: We have a voice note here from Samuel in London. Let's play it.

[SOUND EFFECT: VOICE NOTE PLAYING]

Samuel: "Hey Tomi, hey Ada. Listen, the worst betrayal of my life happened last Christmas. My auntie—God bless her—decided to be 'healthy' and made Jollof using cauliflower rice. I cried real tears. It was like eating seasoned sadness. Please tell the people, Jollof requires carbs!"

TOMI: Samuel, we are sending you thoughts and prayers. Cauliflower Jollof is a hate crime. It's a violation of the Geneva Convention.

ADA: I'm with Samuel. You can't health-hack everything. Let Jollof be Jollof.

TOMI: Lastly, a tweet from @Aminata_Dakar: "Nigeria and Ghana are like two noisy children fighting over a toy I bought them. Senegal is the mother. Eat your food and be quiet."

ADA: [Laughs loudly] Aminata dropped the mic! She ended all of us!

[TRANSITION STING]

SEGMENT 6 – POP CULTURE

ADA: You know, looking at those tweets, it's amazing how social media completely globalized this dish.

TOMI: It really did. Ten years ago, the Jollof debate was just something you argued about in the barbershop or at a pan-African student union meeting. Now? It's global news.

ADA: Remember when Jamie Oliver tried to make Jollof rice and put coriander and lemon in it?

TOMI: [Groans] Please, do not raise my blood pressure. Jamie's "Jollof" united West Africans faster than the African Union ever could. Ghanaians, Nigerians, and Senegalese stopped fighting each other and formed a digital army to attack his recipe!

ADA: It was beautiful to see! Social media has turned the Jollof Wars into a brilliant meme culture. When musicians like Akon, or Cardi B, or actors like John Boyega go to West Africa, the first question interviewers ask them is, "Which Jollof is better?"

TOMI: And they always look terrified! Because they know if they answer wrong, their mentions will be on fire for three business days.

ADA: Exactly. But jokes aside, this pop culture moment is actually incredible for West African identity. Food is a soft power. It puts our culture on the map. Because of these debates, Jollof is now recognized worldwide. You can find Jollof on menus in London, New York, Tokyo.

TOMI: The rivalry is basically a massive, continent-wide marketing campaign for our food. We are fighting, but we are selling out the stadiums!

[TRANSITION STING]

SEGMENT 7 – PERSONAL STORIES

ADA: Okay, Tomi. Let's get a little sentimental. Take off the comedian hat for a second. What is your favorite, most core memory involving Jollof?

TOMI: Ah, man. It has to be Christmas day at my grandmother's house in Ibadan. I was maybe nine years old. In a Nigerian household, the night before Christmas is chaos. There are cows being prepped, chickens being chased. But by 6:00 AM on Christmas morning, the giant iron pots go on the fire in the backyard.

My cousins and I would sit on the wall, just smelling the smoke. My grandma would take a small, enamel bowl, scrape the very bottom of the pot—the crunchiest, most flavorful part—and hand it to us before the guests arrived. It tasted like love. It tasted like family. You couldn't replicate that flavor in a Michelin-star restaurant if you tried.

ADA: That is beautiful. For me, it's actually a funny failure. When I first moved to the UK for my master's degree, I missed home so much. I missed Nigerian food. So, I called my mom and wrote down her Jollof recipe.

But I didn't realize that the tomatoes in the UK are much sweeter and have more water than the ones in Lagos. And the peppers aren't as hot. So I made a massive pot for my new international friends, hyping it up for days. "I am making the legendary Jollof!"

TOMI: Oh no...

ADA: Tomi, it came out looking like pink, soggy risotto.

TOMI: [Bursts into laughter] Pink risotto?!

ADA: Yes! It was sweet. It was mushy. My friends, being polite British people, ate it and said, "Oh, it's very... interesting." I went to my room and cried. But it taught me to respect the craft! Cooking Jollof abroad is a science. You have to use tomato paste to cheat the color and hunt down actual scotch bonnets!

TOMI: Every diaspora child has that exact trauma. The pink risotto phase is a rite of passage!

[TRANSITION STING]

SEGMENT 8 – RAPID FIRE

TOMI: Alright! Time to crank the energy back up. Ada, I have 20 rapid-fire questions for you. You have two seconds to answer. No long explanations.

ADA: Oh boy. Okay, I'm ready.

TOMI: 1. Beans or Jollof?

ADA: Jollof.

TOMI: 2. Fried plantain or Fried yam?

ADA: Fried plantain.

TOMI: 3. Coke or Malt with your Jollof?

ADA: Ice cold Malt!

TOMI: 4. Suya before or after Jollof?

ADA: After.

TOMI: 5. Homemade or Takeaway?

ADA: Homemade.

TOMI: 6. Christmas rice or Birthday rice?

ADA: Christmas rice!

TOMI: 7. Boiled egg or Fried fish?

ADA: Fried fish.

TOMI: 8. Eating with a spoon or your bare hand?

ADA: Spoon for Jollof, hands for swallow.

TOMI: 9. Goat meat or Beef?

ADA: Goat meat.

TOMI: 10. Water on the side or Juice?

ADA: Water, you need it for the pepper!

TOMI: 11. Breakfast Jollof or Dinner Jollof?

ADA: Breakfast leftover Jollof is undefeated!

TOMI: 12. Foil paper cover or Plastic bag cover while steaming?

ADA: Foil paper, please. Plastic melts!

TOMI: 13. Maggi or Knorr?

ADA: Knorr!

TOMI: 14. White onions or Red onions?

ADA: Red onions for the color.

TOMI: 15. Blender or Mortar and Pestle for the pepper?

ADA: Blender, I'm lazy.

TOMI: 16. Ghana Jollof or Senegal Jollof?

ADA: Oh, don't trap me... Senegal.

TOMI: 17. Burn the bottom intentionally or accidentally?

ADA: Intentionally.

TOMI: 18. Share your Jollof or eat alone?

ADA: Eat alone!

TOMI: 19. Coleslaw or Macaroni salad on the side?

ADA: Coleslaw.

TOMI: 20. Who owns the pot?!

ADA: WEST AFRICA OWNS THE POT!

TOMI: [Laughs] Good save, good save! You survived!

[TRANSITION STING]

SEGMENT 9 – FOOD FACTS

ADA: Alright, let's drop some quick knowledge before we wrap up. Here are 10 surprising facts about the ingredients that make up our favorite dish.

TOMI: Hit them, professor!

ADA: 1. Tomatoes are not native to Africa! They originated in South America and were brought to West Africa by the Portuguese in the 16th century.

TOMI: 2. Same with the Scotch Bonnet pepper! Native to the Caribbean and Central America, but now the absolute backbone of West African heat.

ADA: 3. But rice *is* native! *Oryza glaberrima*, also known as African rice, has been cultivated in West Africa for over 3,000 years, long before Asian rice arrived.

TOMI: 4. Firewood cooking isn't just about heat. Certain woods, like mahogany or mango wood, release specific aromatic compounds that literally flavor the food.

ADA: 5. The red color of Jollof doesn't just come from tomatoes; it heavily relies on the sweet red bell peppers, which we boil down to a thick paste.

TOMI: 6. In Senegal, the dish *Thiéboudienne* is actually recognized by UNESCO! In 2021, it was added to the Representative List of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity.

ADA: 7. Jollof rice is culturally a "celebration" dish because, historically, meat, fish, and imported rice were expensive. Cooking it signified wealth and festivity.

TOMI: 8. The word "Jolof" doesn't mean food; it refers to the Jolof Empire, which was a powerful West African state from 1350 to 1549.

ADA: 9. The steam technique used to cook Jollof is practically an ancient pressure-cooking method. By sealing the pot with foil or heavy lids, you force the rice to cook in the steam of the tomato vapor, not boiling water.

TOMI: 10. August 22nd is World Jollof Rice Day. Yes, we have our own holiday. Mark your calendars!

[TRANSITION STING]

CLOSING

ADA: As we wrap up today's episode, I want to say this. The Jollof Wars are loud, they are funny, and they are fiercely competitive. But underneath all the Twitter banter and the friendly shade, is a deep, profound love for who we are as West Africans.

TOMI: Exactly. When a Nigerian argues with a Ghanaian about rice, we aren't actually fighting. We are acknowledging each other. We are saying, "I see you, brother. I see you, sister. We share this history."

ADA: Food connects people. It crosses borders that politicians draw. Whether you are eating the broken rice in Dakar, the Jasmine rice in Accra, or the smoky bottom pot in Lagos... you are eating history. You are eating resilience, creativity, and joy.

TOMI: Every country contributes something unique to the table. And honestly, the best Jollof in the world isn't defined by geography. The best Jollof is the one you share with the people you love. Even if they use too much ginger.

ADA: [Laughs] You just couldn't resist!

TOMI: I had to! But seriously, family, thank you for sitting at *The Gist Table* with us today. Keep cooking, keep eating, and keep the culture alive.

ADA: If you enjoyed today's episode, hit that subscribe button, share this with your friends from neighboring countries, and let us know your Jollof recipes on our social media!

TOMI: Until next time, stay spicy, and don't let anyone serve you white rice at a wedding!

ADA: Bye, everyone!

[OUTRO MUSIC SWELLS - UPBEAT AFROBEATS]

[MUSIC PLAYS FOR 10 SECONDS THEN FADES OUT]